We have no satisfactory news from Camp. The Shah with his army was before Herat and had been there some time without taking it and it appeared to be doubtful whether he would succeed or not.[48] If he fails his army will be in a bad state for want of provisions and will have to retreat some twenty marches in the depth of winter, where there are no supplies, with an enemy harrassing their rear, as the nearest point where they could winter is Meshed, or even where they could remain in safety. Having no good news from the camp throws a gloom over our market; else prices are very good and stocks in hand light. Bonham is holding for a rise and I think if we had decent news from the camp prices would advance. Silk has been too dear for the Constantin'le or London market this year, not a *lb* has gone that way. What has been bought has been taken to Moskow or Baghdad or used in home consumption. But there is yet a good deal on hand and the speculators have been let in for it this year, as they bought judging from the prices of last.

I have two little spaniels who fight as game as any terriers could and the most curious part of it is that they are the best friends possible until I rub their noses together, then they begin, and would not leave off until one was beaten to a stand still. This I do not allow but when I think they have done enough to *satisfy their honor* I seperate them and give them each a good dinner. I consider that the dinner balances the acct, it would not be right to make them fight for nothing. However I do not let them fight above once a month. The other day a cat came into my garden with a felonious intent, that is, to eat my pigeons, I had in the two little dogs, and the cat shewed good fight for about half an hour, and then when I found he was tired and that the dogs would have worried him I let him go, thinking that as he had done his *devoir* in the *mélée* as a gallant knight, he deserved his liberty, and being quite sure he would never look with a longing eye upon my pigeons again.

My pigeons are tumblers and are many of them so tame that they will allow themselves to be caught carried about in the pocket or tossed up into the air. After flying about and tumbling over and over they come down again and will allow themselves to be caught again.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, December 8, 1838*

Mr Ruddeby starts to day for England. Mr McNeill gives him dispatches as far as Constantinople, and as he takes the news of the Shahs being on his way back from Herat and of his having made peace with the Afghans I hope it may be of some use to him. Political affairs in this country now look well enough. Mr McNeill and his suit instead of leaving the country and declaring

[48] Edward's prediction proved true; the Shah failed to take Herat, but failed to make his peace with the British until the threat of military measures compelled him to do so.

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